

Practice Assignments for *God is Breath*

Class 1

What does it mean to be part of the *sangha*, the group attunement, that we are creating at the beginning of this program of classes? This is my prayer for what it will mean to all of us, myself included:

May we wholeheartedly agree to study and take to heart the written materials assigned, and engage in the teachings and practices on a daily basis, as well as in the midst of everyday life. When we forget, may that forgetfulness simply remind us to remember to re-engage with our practice without self-recrimination. May we breathe a breath of unity and support for all who undertake this journey.

Some specific practices to take on for the first month:

Recite the Sufi Invocation.

Set your intention. Find your deepest most authentic prayer to be open and receptive, to merge with the Beloved, to overcome separation from the Source, the One.

Daily practices:

15 minutes sitting meditation

Precede the meditation with 33 repetitions of Ya Raqib, a wazifah that helps bring our full loving attention to our concentration.

If necessary, build up to this starting with five minutes.

Allow yourself to breathe naturally. Notice the rhythm of this breath and consciously maintain this rhythm for a while. Gradually allow the breath to become longer and more refined. Become aware of the small natural pause at the top and bottom of the breath.

Place your attention on the magnetism (prana) that is carried by the breath. You are drawing from the all-pervading life in space. Notice the direct connection between the ease and refinement of the breath and this magnetism. Center your awareness in the heart (middle of the chest) and consciously bring the magnetism into the heart as you inhale, and radiate it as you exhale.

Call all this feeling forth as love, then as God's love. Using the rhythm that has been established in your breath you begin slowly intoning in your thought, "Allah, Allah", so that the repetition takes the full length of the breath, letting it naturally fill the heart and breath with the joy of the divine presence and the longing for unity with the One.

- Tip: as you proceed in the practice stay attentive to flow of the breath, long, refined, rhythmical. If it begins to stray from this, gently bring it back.
- Option: if you feel inwardly so inclined, intone "Toward The One" in harmony with your breath rather than "Allah, Allah," as above.

20 Purification Breaths and Healing Prayer

There are many different forms in which this practice is done. In this class we are placing our attention throughout on the avenues of purification mentioned in the prayer that follows the breaths.

The Purification Breaths:

Five times slowly breathe *Ya Shafee* (O Healer) in through the nose and *Ya Kafiyy* (O Remedy) out through the nose.

Five times slowly breathe *Ya Shafee* in through the nose and *Ya Kafiyy* out through the mouth.

Five times slowly breathe *Ya Shafee* in through the mouth and *Ya Kafiyy* out through the nose.

Five times slowly breath *Ya Shafee* in through the mouth and *Ya Kafiyy* out through the mouth.

Follow with the healing prayer *Nayaz*:

“Beloved Lord, almighty God, through the rays of the Sun, through the waves of the air, through Thy all-pervading life in space, purify and revivify me, and I pray, heal my body, heart, and soul.”

Throughout the breathing exercises and in the course of daily activity remember at least twice a day, and perhaps more, to become attentive to your breath and receptively feel the purifying blessing of the movement of the air, the rays of the sun, and the all-pervading life in space reaching and revivifying your physical body and your heart, and refreshing your soul.

At least once a week:

Walking Practices

- Practice the walk of the Hara center (a few inches below the navel). Direct the breath in this center as you walk. Deliberate, rhythmical, four steps as you inhale, four steps as you exhale. Integrate all the energy and magnetism you feel into your physical body feeling it offering good health, strength and steadiness in your life.
- Practice taking a walk in nature using the phrase “Toward the One” on the breath, and focused in the heart center. Begin by using this thought to become fully attentive to your breath. Clearly shine the light of your intention upon the path of your life to continually move toward wholeness of being. While continuing to concentrate in this way, establish in mind a physical destination for your walk. Connect with that destination in your heart and breath, and feel the destination drawing you toward it.

- Practice other walking concentrations that we took up in class as prompted by your feeling. Especially recommended is the walk of attunement with Murshid Samuel Lewis breathing with the realization that “peace is power.”

To be done at any time:

Journaling

Everyone is asked to keep an ongoing Journal that reflects your experiences with your breath when you focused your attention on it during the day and at regular practice times. Take note of the condition of your breath at various times, such as its rhythm or lack of it, refinement or coarseness, breadth, livingness or dullness, length of inhalation or exhalation, sweetness or sourness of feeling, naturalness or artificialness, Jelal or Jamal quality.

What is your breath reflecting of inner and outer conditions? What arises in the way of guidance or felt connection when your breath is in a meditative condition or when you are receptively listening for the Spirit of Guidance?

Some people may have resistance to journaling, but please write in your Journal at least once a week. It helps to bring a certain objectivity of mind to our practice that is useful.

Attention to breath

Finally, be attentive to the breath throughout the day and look to apply the teachings we have received. By the Grace of God, may we all find the rhythm to lovingly persevere and succeed in our practice.

Love and Blessings,
Wali Ali